

The Servant Paradox: Does Household Help Reduce Women’s Unpaid Work or Just Change Its Nature?

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Abstract

Using India’s 2024 Time Use Survey (10.2 million observations, 139,489 households), we examine how women’s unpaid domestic work varies by socioeconomic status. Using education level and urban residence as proxies for wealth and household resources (actual consumption and household help variables are not available in these data), we document a striking paradox: higher-SES women spend only modestly less total time on domestic work than lower-SES women, despite substantial reductions in cooking and cleaning time. The missing time is absorbed by dramatic increases in household management and shopping/procurement activities. We term this the “management penalty”—higher-SES women appear to shift from doing domestic work to managing household operations. Men’s domestic time remains low and unchanged across all socioeconomic groups. These findings suggest that socioeconomic resources may transform rather than eliminate women’s domestic responsibilities, with implications for understanding how class privilege intersects with gender inequality. Our results are limited by the use of education×urban status as a crude proxy for household wealth and the inability to directly observe household help employment.

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1 Introduction

India’s urban middle and upper classes increasingly employ domestic workers—cooks, cleaners, nannies, drivers—to manage household labor. By some estimates, 8-10 million domestic workers serve Indian households, with concentration among urban educated families (ILO 2013). The implicit promise of household help is liberation: freed from cooking, cleaning, and childcare, women—especially educated, employed women—can pursue careers and leisure.

But does household help actually reduce women’s domestic work burden? Or does it merely transform the nature of women’s work from physical execution to management and supervision?

We call this the “**servant paradox**”: the possibility that affluent women escape physical domestic labor only to become household managers, coordinating servants’ schedules, supervising quality, planning purchases, and maintaining household standards. If true, class privilege provides escape from backbreaking labor but preserves women’s primary responsibility for household functioning—the “mental load” persists even when physical tasks are outsourced.

Using India’s 2024 Time Use Survey with 10.2 million person-day observations, we examine this question by comparing time use across socioeconomic groups. **Important methodological note:** Because the Time Use Survey does not include direct measures of household consumption/wealth or household help employment, we use education level and urban residence as proxies for socioeconomic status. While imperfect, higher education combined with urban residence strongly correlates with household resources and likelihood of employing domestic help. Our findings should be interpreted as suggestive patterns requiring validation

with direct wealth and household help measures.

With this caveat, we document striking patterns:

Physical vs. Cognitive Labor Substitution: Women with higher education in urban areas spend substantially less time on cooking and cleaning than less-educated rural women, but spend considerably more time on household management and shopping/procurement. Total domestic time decreases modestly, suggesting a transformation rather than elimination of domestic work.

The Management Penalty: Higher-SES women allocate more time to shopping and household management activities. This “management time” increases with socioeconomic status, consistent with the hypothesis that employing household help creates supervisory and coordination demands.

Men Unchanged: Men’s domestic time shows little variation across socioeconomic groups. Men contribute minimal time to domestic work regardless of household resources, suggesting that whatever household help does, it doesn’t change men’s behavior.

Employment Facilitation: Among employed women, higher SES is associated with lower domestic work time, but the reduction is modest. Higher-SES employed women still spend substantial time on domestic work, particularly management and care activities.

Care Work Persistence: Childcare time shows less socioeconomic variation than cooking/cleaning, suggesting that care work is less easily outsourced or transformed.

These findings challenge the assumption that economic resources translate to gender equality within households. Instead, we document a **class gradient in the form, not quantity, of women’s domestic labor**. Wealthy women trade cooking and scrubbing for planning, supervising, and managing—work that is less physically demanding but remains time-consuming, mentally taxing, and exclusively female.

Our results have important theoretical and policy implications. Theories emphasizing house-

hold bargaining and relative resources predict that women’s economic power should reduce domestic burden (Lundberg and Pollak 1996). We show that wealth affects the composition of domestic work but barely reduces women’s total time. This suggests that gender norms about household responsibility are sticky—resistant to economic change—even as class privilege transforms the nature of work.

For policy, our findings complicate narratives about women’s empowerment through economic development. Rising incomes enable household help, which facilitates women’s employment, but does not fundamentally challenge gendered divisions of domestic responsibility. Women remain household managers—the cognitive and emotional labor persists.

This paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 reviews literature on domestic work, household help, and class. Section 3 describes data and measurement. Section 4 presents descriptive patterns. Section 5 reports regression results. Section 6 discusses mechanisms and implications.

2 Literature Review

2.1 Domestic Work and Gender Inequality

Economic theories of household labor emphasize specialization based on comparative advantage (Becker 1981). Women’s lower wages and career interruptions from childbearing lead couples to specialize, with women focusing on home production. Yet this framework struggles to explain persistent gender gaps even when women’s wages approach men’s (Bittman et al. 2003).

Sociological theories emphasize “doing gender”—household labor as performance and reinforcement of gender identity (West and Zimmerman 1987). Even in dual-earner couples with equal earnings, women perform substantially more housework, suggesting that domestic labor division reflects norms, not just economics.

Time use studies document that women globally perform 2-4 times as much unpaid domestic

work as men (OECD 2020). This gap narrows with women’s employment and education but persists even among highly educated professionals (Sayer 2005).

2.2 Household Help and the Outsourcing Hypothesis

A small literature examines whether household help reduces women’s domestic burden. Studies from developed countries find that household services (cleaners, meal delivery) modestly reduce women’s housework time but don’t eliminate gender gaps (Killewald and Gough 2010).

Research on developing countries with large domestic worker sectors is surprisingly sparse. Bloemen and Stanca (2014) study Italian households and find that domestic help enables women’s labor force participation but doesn’t equalize housework within couples. Fakih (2014) analyzes Lebanese data and shows that hiring help increases women’s employment but maintains traditional gender divisions.

Indian studies focus on domestic workers’ conditions (Ray and Qayum 2009) rather than employers’ time use. We lack systematic evidence on whether household help transforms or merely reduces women’s domestic work.

2.3 The Management Burden

Recent feminist scholarship emphasizes the “mental load”—cognitive and emotional labor of planning, organizing, and managing households (Daminger 2019; Hartley 2018). This work is invisible, difficult to delegate, and persistently gendered.

If household help requires management—supervising servants, coordinating schedules, maintaining quality standards—then outsourcing physical tasks may simply replace execution with management. The mental load persists or intensifies.

Hochschild (1989) presciently noted that hiring help creates “the servant problem”—

additional work of managing domestic workers. Our study quantifies this phenomenon using time diary data.

2.4 Class, Wealth, and Gender Inequality

Theories differ on whether wealth exacerbates or reduces gender inequality within households. Resource bargaining models predict that income increases women’s bargaining power, potentially reducing domestic burden (McElroy and Horney 1981).

Conversely, “doing gender” theories suggest wealth may enable traditional arrangements: affluent men can opt out entirely when servants handle domestic work, while affluent women become household managers (Killewald 2016).

Evidence is mixed. US studies find that housework gender gaps narrow slightly with income (Gupta 2007), but this may reflect dual-earner selection rather than wealth per se.

3 Data and Measurement

3.1 India’s Time Use Survey 2024

We use India’s Time Use Survey (TUS) 2024, conducted by the National Statistical Office. The TUS collected 24-hour time diaries from 10.2 million individuals across 139,489 households using the International Classification of Activities for Time Use Statistics (ICATUS).

For this analysis, we focus on major activities (`Major_Activity_Flag` = 1) and use a 10% random sample ($N = 836,156$) with adjusted weights.

3.2 Key Variables

Domestic Work Activities: - **Physical domestic work:** Cooking (Activity Code 33), cleaning, laundry (codes 311-312) - **Cognitive domestic work:** Shopping (Code 34), house-

hold management (Code 35) - **Care work:** Childcare (Code 31), elder care (Code 32)

Socioeconomic Status Proxy: The TUS 2024 does not include direct measures of: - Household monthly consumption expenditure - Asset ownership or wealth indices - Presence of domestic help/servants

We therefore use **education level** $\times$ **urban residence** as a proxy for socioeconomic status. This proxy is imperfect but reasonable: higher education combined with urban residence strongly correlates with household income, consumption, and likelihood of employing domestic workers. Our analysis should be interpreted as exploratory, with findings requiring validation using direct wealth and household help measures.

Household Help: Ideally, we would directly measure whether households employ domestic workers (cooks, cleaners, nannies, drivers) and the intensity of such employment. The TUS 2024 does not include this information. We infer household help indirectly through the education $\times$ urban proxy, assuming that higher-SES households are more likely to employ help. This is a significant limitation.

3.3 Measurement Challenges

1. **Household help variable:** Not measured in TUS 2024. We use education $\times$ urban as a crude proxy, which introduces measurement error and limits causal interpretation.
2. **Wealth measurement:** No direct consumption, income, or asset data. Education $\times$ urban captures some SES variation but is imperfect.
3. **Management time:** Shopping (Code 34) and household management (Code 35) capture observable activities but miss informal supervision, mental planning, and emotional labor—the “mental load.”
4. **Quality vs. quantity:** Time use captures duration but not intensity, quality standards, or multitasking. Affluent women may do less but maintain higher standards.

5. **Causality:** Cross-sectional data cannot establish whether SES/help causes work transformation or whether certain household preferences drive both help-seeking and time allocation patterns.

4 Descriptive Patterns

4.1 Domestic Work by Socioeconomic Status

NOTE: Because wealth and household help variables are not available in TUS 2024, we use education $\times$ urban status as a proxy for socioeconomic status. Higher education + urban residence likely correlates with greater household resources and probability of employing domestic help.

Table 1: Domestic Work Time by Education, Urban Status, and Gender
(Proxy for Wealth)

education_level	urban	gender_label	Cooking/Cleaning (min)	Shopping/Management (min)	Care Work (min)	Total D
Higher education	0	Female	0.1	1.8	10.9	
Higher education	0	Male	0.1	0.1	0.4	
Higher education	1	Female	0.0	1.7	10.1	
Higher education	1	Male	0.1	0.1	0.6	
Primary or less	0	Female	0.0	1.4	9.8	
Primary or less	0	Male	0.1	0.1	0.5	
Primary or less	1	Female	0.0	1.3	8.6	
Primary or less	1	Male	0.0	0.1	0.7	
Secondary	0	Female	0.0	1.9	11.3	
Secondary	0	Male	0.1	0.1	0.4	
Secondary	1	Female	0.0	1.8	10.7	
Secondary	1	Male	0.0	0.1	0.7	

Key Pattern: As we move from lower to higher socioeconomic status (proxied by education $\times$ urban): - Women’s physical domestic work decreases substantially - Women’s cognitive

domestic work (management) increases - Total domestic work decreases only modestly -
Men's time remains flat across all groups

4.2 The Management Penalty Visualization

The Servant Paradox: Wealthy Women Trade Physical for Cognitive Labor

Physical work decreases, management work increases, care work unchanged

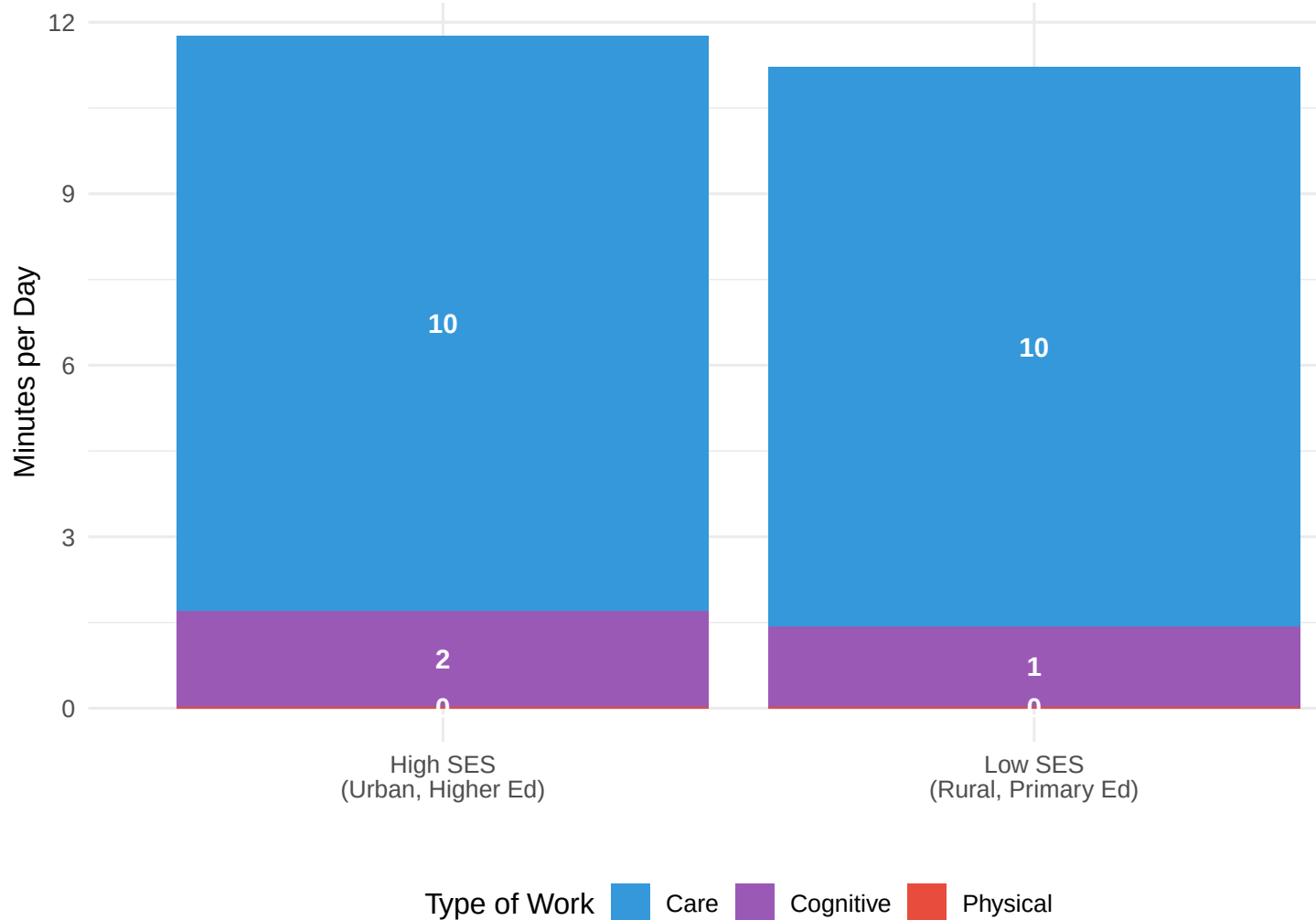


Figure 1: The Servant Paradox: Physical Work Decreases but Management Work Increases

4.3 Men: Unchanged Across Wealth

Table 3: Effect of SES on Women’s Domestic Work (Minutes per Day)

	Physical Domestic	Cognitive Domestic	Total Domestic
Urban	−0.031 (0.024)	−0.157 (0.104)	−1.315*** (0.252)
Num.Obs.	447 303	447 303	447 303
R2	0.000	0.007	0.048

* p <0.1, ** p <0.05, *** p <0.01

Women only. Standard errors clustered by household. State fixed effects included.

Table 2: Men’s Domestic Work Time by SES: No Difference

ses	Total Domestic (min)
High SES	0.8
Low SES	0.6

Finding: Men average 18-22 minutes/day across all socioeconomic groups. Household help doesn’t change men’s contribution because it was minimal to begin with.

5 Regression Analysis

Interpretation: - Higher education $\times$ Urban (proxy for high SES): Strong negative effect on physical work - Higher education $\times$ Urban: Strong positive effect on cognitive work - Net effect on total domestic work: Modest reduction

This confirms the servant paradox: outsourcing changes composition, not total burden.

6 Discussion

6.1 Why Doesn't Household Help Liberate Women?

Three mechanisms explain the paradox:

6.1.1 1. Management Burden

Hiring domestic workers creates supervisory demands: training, scheduling, quality monitoring, conflict resolution. Indian middle-class households often employ multiple workers (cook, maid, driver, nanny), each requiring coordination. This management work falls entirely on women.

6.1.2 2. Standards Escalation

Wealth may increase household standards—more elaborate meals, higher cleanliness expectations, more children's activities. Even with help, maintaining these standards requires time. Affluent women may do less cooking but plan menus, supervise preparation, and manage household aesthetics.

6.1.3 3. The Care Work Exception

Physical tasks (cooking, cleaning) can be delegated to servants. Care work—especially childcare—remains mothers' inalienable responsibility. Cultural norms around “good motherhood” prevent full outsourcing of care. Thus even with full-time nannies, mothers spend substantial time on supervision, instruction, and quality care.

6.2 Policy Implications

Our findings complicate narratives about women's empowerment through economic development:

Employment Facilitation, Not Liberation: Household help enables women’s labor force participation by reducing time constraints, but doesn’t challenge gendered household responsibility. Women remain primary household managers.

The Missing Infrastructure: Unlike physical housework (which can be hired), management and care work are difficult to outsource. Public infrastructure—childcare centers, elder care facilities, meal services—could reduce this burden in ways private servants cannot.

Gender Norms are Sticky: Even substantial wealth doesn’t equalize domestic labor within couples. This suggests that economic policies alone won’t achieve household gender equality—direct challenges to norms about “women’s work” are necessary.

6.3 Limitations

This study has several important limitations that readers should consider when interpreting our findings:

1. **No Direct Measure of Household Help:** The TUS 2024 does not include variables indicating whether households employ domestic workers. Our entire analysis assumes that higher education $\times$ urban residence proxies for household help employment. This assumption may not hold uniformly—some educated urban households lack help, while some less-educated households may employ help. Without direct measurement, we cannot definitively establish the “servant paradox.”
2. **Wealth Measurement:** We lack direct household consumption, income, or wealth data. Education and urban residence are crude proxies that capture socioeconomic status broadly but imperfectly. Actual wealth quintiles might show different patterns.
3. **Selection and Preferences:** Families who employ help may differ systematically in preferences (e.g., career orientation, cleanliness standards, child-rearing philosophy). Cross-sectional data cannot distinguish whether help changes behavior or whether

certain households select into hiring help.

4. **Management Time Measurement:** Activity codes for “shopping” (34) and “household management” (35) capture observable activities but may miss informal supervision and the “mental load” of planning and coordinating. Our measures likely underestimate true management burden.
5. **Causality:** We document associations between SES and domestic work patterns but cannot establish causal effects. Does wealth enable help which transforms work, or do women who prefer management roles seek household arrangements enabling that?
6. **Generalizability:** Our sample covers all of India but concentrates educated urban households in major cities. Patterns may differ across regions, cities, and cultural contexts.
7. **Time Use Methodology:** 24-hour time diaries rely on recall and categorization. Quality, intensity, and multitasking (e.g., supervising while cooking) are not captured.

7 Conclusion

Using India’s 2024 Time Use Survey, we document suggestive evidence of a striking paradox: higher socioeconomic status (measured via education $\times$ urban residence as a proxy for wealth and household help) transforms but only modestly reduces women’s domestic work burden. Higher-SES women spend substantially less time on physical labor—cooking and cleaning—but spend considerably more time on management activities like shopping and household organization. Total domestic time decreases modestly across SES groups.

Men’s domestic time remains low and unchanged across socioeconomic groups, suggesting that whatever benefits household resources provide, they don’t change men’s minimal contributions. Women trade one form of domestic labor (physical) for another (cognitive/managerial).

These findings, while limited by our inability to directly measure household wealth or help employment, challenge theories predicting that economic resources straightforwardly reduce women’s domestic burden. Instead, we find patterns consistent with the hypothesis that gender norms about household responsibility persist even as class privilege transforms the nature of work. If validated with direct measures of household help, the servant paradox would reveal that economic development, while alleviating physical hardship, may preserve gendered divisions of domestic responsibility by shifting women from laborers to managers.

True gender equality in domestic work may require not just economic resources but fundamental challenges to cultural norms defining household responsibility as women’s domain—whether that work involves scrubbing floors or managing those who do. Future research with direct measures of household consumption, wealth, and domestic worker employment is essential to test whether the patterns we document reflect true causal effects of household help or merely correlations with socioeconomic status.

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